

Work@tech

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**SMARTER SURFACES:**

A smarter way to do business?

It's an interactive world out there. How do you use that to better your enterprise?

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We live in a world where we're using gestures everywhere. Where touch-screens were only in the realm of the geek, they're now part and parcel of our lives and aged grandmothers pinch-to-zoom just as easily as toddlers thanks to the plethora of smartphones and tablets that have permeated our lives. So much so in fact that traditional buttons and switches don't seem to cut it anymore.

As a company, you can take advantage of this fact, the gesture-ready human race, and leverage it to your advantage. There are many companies and organizations that provide services that will allow you to create

a custom, gesture-based interactive environment for you to best showcase your work and/or draw customers in. In fact, you don't even need to rely on someone else to do it for you, with a bit of patience, a bit of cash and some intelligent use of yours (or someone else's) programming skills, you can create your very own gesture-ready display.

How do these "interactive surfaces" work?

Anywhere. Most commercial implementations of this technology involve the use of projectors and Kinect style sensors or infra-red cameras to capture and interpret gestures and other movement. The technology involved is very simple, off-the-shelf components will easily suffice. You essentially have a projector that

projects the graphics onto a surface of your choice (a glass surface, a wall or a floor) and a sensor unit that usually comprises of infra-red LEDs and a sensor. The setup will be hooked up to a PC, you don't need a fancy one, and the requisite software will manage the whole thing for you. As long as you have a surface to project on and the sensor can see that surface, you can create an interactive surface.

The problem is in implementing the system for yourself as there would be quite a bit of image processing (IP) knowledge involved. Companies that provide this service are almost always using the same type of tech to create that surface, though the design may vary slightly, and then leverage their experience in IP and app design to create a solution that suits your needs.